

E091

Building A Successful IT Organization

Armored Drill

8 concepts · 12 items · 4 transfer items

What this is. Every concept in this course's public description, re-asked with more disguise than a practice test uses. Each stem carries facts that do not decide it. Every wrong answer is a named trap.

Source. Scope from the course's public description in the WGU Institutional Catalog (September 2026); items written from the field's standard body of knowledge. No WGU assessment item, course material or proprietary content is used or reproduced. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Western Governors University.

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How to run it

Paper first. Pencil. One pass, no notes, a timer if you want the pressure.

1. **Before you read the options**, fill the strip under the item: the target word (what is actually being asked), and the one fact in the stem that decides it.
2. **Principle before arithmetic**. Name the rule, then compute.
3. **Camouflage**. Most of every stem does not matter. Ask: which single fact decides this?
4. **Inverse pairs are the bait**. If two options are opposites, one of them is the trap built for you.
5. **Mark sure, unsure or guess** honestly. Sure-and-wrong is the most valuable miss on the page — it is a wrong mental model.
6. **Absolutes** (always, never, guarantee) are usually wrong. And recognizing an answer is not the same as owning it.
7. Items with a **heavy black bar** on the left are **transfer items**: the same principle, reversed or solved for a different variable.
8. Stop at the STOP page. Then grade, fill the triage grid, and tally the traps you fell for. The biggest tally is what you drill next.

The strip, filled in, looks like this:

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	_____	

Items

1.

A multinational with six business units wants consistent security standards and shared infrastructure, but each unit wants its own developers close to its customers. The company's headquarters is in a converted textile mill. Which IT structure fits best?

- A. Outsource all IT to one vendor.
- B. Decentralized.
- C. Centralized.
- D. Federated (hybrid).

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

2. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

What is the main advantage of a centralized IT structure?

- A. Fast responsiveness to each unit's local needs.
- B. Business units own their own IT budgets.
- C. It removes the need for IT governance.
- D. Economies of scale and consistent standards.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

3.

An IT director who recently finished an executive MBA drafts goals for next year. Which goal is SMART?

- A. Cut resolution time 90% within one week with no new resources.
- B. Achieve 100% uptime forever.
- C. Improve user satisfaction with IT.
- D. Reduce average help-desk resolution time from 26 to 18 hours by June 30.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

4. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

The goal “Migrate 40 of our 60 file servers to the cloud” is missing which SMART element?

- A. Measurable.
- B. Specific.
- C. Time-bound.
- D. Nothing; the goal is complete.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

5.

A new CIO at a regional credit union, who previously led a hospital IT department, is building a three-year IT strategic plan. The board wants the plan by spring. Which step should come before setting specific IT goals?

- A. Reuse the hospital's IT plan.
- B. Draft detailed project schedules.
- C. Assess the business strategy and IT's current state, for example with a SWOT.
- D. Select technologies and vendors.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

6.

A university IT department is building a SWOT. A major cloud vendor it relies on has announced a 40% price increase next year. The department also just redesigned its intranet. How should the price increase be classified?

- A. Threat.
- B. Weakness.
- C. Opportunity.
- D. Strength, because the new intranet can absorb it.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

7. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Which item belongs in the Weaknesses quadrant of an IT SWOT?

- A. The IT staff lacks cloud security skills.
- B. Strong long-term vendor relationships.
- C. A competitor is recruiting away IT staff across the region.
- D. Cloud costs are falling industry-wide.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

8.

At a manufacturing firm, a committee of executives decides which IT investments get funded and sets the firm's risk appetite. The IT operations manager schedules patching and assigns technicians. The committee meets in the boardroom on the fourth floor. Which activity is governance?

- A. The committee's funding and risk-appetite decisions.
- B. All of them, since everything IT does is governance.
- C. Assigning technicians to tickets.
- D. Scheduling the patching.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

9.

A mid-size retailer wants one executive to align technology investments with business strategy and sit on the executive committee. It already has a head of infrastructure who has run the data center for 15 years. Which role fits?

- A. Chief Information Security Officer (CISO).
- B. Chief Information Officer (CIO).
- C. Promote the head of infrastructure because of tenure.
- D. Chief Technology Officer (CTO).

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

10.

An IT scorecard includes budget variance, user satisfaction, change-failure rate, and hours of training per engineer. The IT director presents the scorecard quarterly. Which perspective does hours of training per engineer belong to?

- A. Customer.
- B. Internal process.
- C. Learning and growth.
- D. Financial, because training costs money.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

11. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Which measure belongs in the customer perspective of an IT balanced scorecard?

- A.** Certifications earned by IT staff.
- B.** Business-user satisfaction with IT services.
- C.** Mean time to restore service.
- D.** IT spending as a percent of revenue.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

12.

A logistics company's competitive edge is its proprietary route-optimization software. It also runs its own email servers and payroll system. The company recently opened a hub in Memphis. Which is the strongest candidate to keep in-house?

- A.** The email servers.
- B.** The route-optimization software.
- C.** The payroll system.
- D.** Nothing; outsourcing everything always cuts cost.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

STOP

Answers and dissection follow. Finish every item and every strip first.

Key and dissection

Struck-through text is the camouflage: facts that do not decide the item.

1. Answer D Concept 1

A multinational with six business units wants consistent security standards and shared infrastructure, but each unit wants its own developers close to its customers. ~~The company's headquarters is in a converted textile mill.~~ Which IT structure fits best?

Target word: structure **Decides:** Needs both shared standards and local developers.

A	Adjacent category	A sourcing choice, not an organizational structure.
B	Confusion set	Gives local control but loses shared standards.
C	Dropped element	Drops the need for local developers.
D	Correct	Centralizes standards and infrastructure while placing developers in units.

2. Answer D Concept 1 · transfer

What is the main advantage of a centralized IT structure?

Target word: work backward from structure to benefit **Decides:** Centralization = scale and standardization.

A	Inverted operation	That is the strength of decentralization.
B	Confusion set	Describes decentralization.
C	Absolute language	Every structure needs governance.
D	Correct	One organization buys, builds, and governs for all.

3. Answer D Concept 2

An IT director ~~who recently finished an executive MBA~~ drafts goals for next year. Which goal is SMART?

Target word: SMART goal **Decides:** Only one is specific, measurable, realistic, and dated.

A	Confusion set	Measurable and dated but not achievable.
B	Absolute language	Not achievable and not time-bound.
C	Dropped element	No measure or deadline.
D	Correct	Specific, measurable, achievable, relevant, and time-bound.

4. Answer C Concept 2 · transfer

The goal "Migrate 40 of our 60 file servers to the cloud" is missing which SMART element?

Target word: find the missing element **Decides:** No deadline is given.

A	Adjacent category	"40 of 60" is already measurable.
B	Confusion set	It names the exact action and systems.
C	Correct	There is no target date.
D	Dropped element	Overlooks the missing deadline.

5. Answer C Concept 3

A new CIO at a regional credit union, ~~who previously led a hospital IT department~~, is building a three-year IT strategic plan. ~~The board wants the plan by spring.~~ Which step should come before setting specific IT goals?

Target word: planning order **Decides:** Goals must follow an assessment of business strategy and current state.

A	Camouflage	A different industry's plan does not fit this organization.
B	Inverted operation	Implementation planning comes after goals.
C	Correct	Assessment grounds goals in real needs.
D	Adjacent category	Tool choices follow goals.

6. Answer A Concept 4

A university IT department is building a SWOT. A major cloud vendor it relies on has announced a 40% price increase next year. ~~The department also just redesigned its intranet.~~ How should the price increase be classified?

Target word: SWOT quadrant **Decides:** Originates outside and harms the department.

A	Correct	An external factor that could hurt the department.
B	Confusion set	Weaknesses are internal.
C	Inverted operation	External but harmful, not helpful.
D	Camouflage	The intranet does not change the nature of the price increase.

7. Answer A Concept 4 · transfer

Which item belongs in the Weaknesses quadrant of an IT SWOT?

Target word: work backward from quadrant to item **Decides:** Weakness = internal and harmful.

A	Correct	An internal limitation.
B	Inverted operation	Internal and helpful: a strength.
C	Confusion set	External: a threat.
D	Adjacent category	External and helpful: an opportunity.

8. Answer A Concept 5

At a manufacturing firm, a committee of executives decides which IT investments get funded and sets the firm's risk appetite. The IT operations manager schedules patching and assigns technicians. ~~The committee meets in the boardroom on the fourth floor.~~ Which activity is governance?

Target word: identify governance **Decides:** Setting direction, priorities, and risk appetite.

A	Correct	Governance sets direction and priorities.
B	Absolute language	Governance and management are distinct.
C	Adjacent category	Operational management.
D	Confusion set	That is management carrying out the work.

9. Answer B Concept 6

A mid-size retailer wants one executive to align technology investments with business strategy and sit on the executive committee. It already has a head of infrastructure ~~who has run the data center for 15 years~~. Which role fits?

Target word: role **Decides:** Business-strategy alignment at executive level.

A	Adjacent category	Focuses on security.
B	Correct	The CIO aligns IT with business strategy.
C	Camouflage	Tenure does not define the role.
D	Confusion set	Focuses on technology direction and products.

10. Answer C Concept 7

An IT scorecard includes budget variance, user satisfaction, change-failure rate, and hours of training per engineer. ~~The IT director presents the scorecard quarterly~~. Which perspective does hours of training per engineer belong to?

Target word: scorecard perspective **Decides:** The measure tracks staff capability.

A	Confusion set	User satisfaction fits there.
B	Adjacent category	Change-failure rate fits there.
C	Correct	Measures building people's capabilities.
D	Dropped element	Files it by cost and drops what it measures.

11. Answer B Concept 7 · transfer

Which measure belongs in the customer perspective of an IT balanced scorecard?

Target word: work backward from perspective to measure **Decides:** Customer = the business users' view.

A	Adjacent category	Learning and growth.
B	Correct	Reflects the customer's view of IT.
C	Inverted operation	An internal process measure, viewed from inside IT.
D	Confusion set	Financial.

12. Answer B Concept 8

A logistics company's competitive edge is its proprietary route-optimization software. It also runs its own email servers and payroll system. ~~The company recently opened a hub in Memphis~~. Which is the strongest candidate to keep in-house?

Target word: core capability **Decides:** Route optimization is the differentiator.

A	Inverted operation	A commodity service, a prime outsourcing candidate.
B	Correct	Core, differentiating capabilities stay in-house.
C	Adjacent category	Important but not differentiating.
D	Absolute language	Outsourcing the differentiator risks the edge.

Triage grid

Write each item number in the box it belongs to.

	Right	Wrong
Sure	Owned.	Concept inversion — top priority. A wrong mental model; it survives rewording.
Unsure / guess	Recognition, not mastery. Re-drill with the transfer.	Not learned yet.

Trap tally

For every miss, find the letter you chose in the key and tally its trap. The biggest number is the pattern to drill.

Trap	What it does	In this drill	Your misses
Dropped element	Leaves out a required term or step.	4	
Wrong stem number	A figure copied from the prompt that is not the answer.	0	
Adjacent category	The right idea in the wrong bucket.	9	
Inverted operation	Direction flipped: add/subtract, cause/effect, higher/lower.	6	
Absolute language	Always, never, guarantee — where judgment applies.	4	
Confusion set	Every option is real; the test is exact role-matching.	10	
Camouflage	Answers a stem fact that was never the question.	3	

Anchor rows — the concept list

One row per concept: the rule to lock in, the trap that catches people, and the tell in the question that signals it.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
1	IT organizational structures	Centralized IT gives scale and consistent standards; decentralized IT gives local responsiveness; federated (hybrid) centralizes shared services and standards while placing some staff in business units.	Picking one extreme when the stem demands both standards and local responsiveness.	Shared standards plus local needs in the same stem.
2	SMART goals	Goals should be specific, measurable, achievable, relevant, and time-bound.	Accepting a measurable goal that lacks a deadline or is unrealistic.	A list of draft goals.
3	Strategic planning sequence	Assess business strategy and current state (e.g., SWOT) before setting IT goals, then plan implementation.	Choosing technologies or timelines first.	“Which step should come before...”
4	SWOT: internal vs. external	Strengths and weaknesses are internal; opportunities and threats are external.	Calling an outside event a weakness.	An item that originates inside or outside the organization.
5	Governance vs. management	Governance sets direction, priorities, and risk appetite; management plans and runs activities within that direction.	Calling operational scheduling governance.	Who funds and sets policy vs. who executes.
6	IT leadership roles	The CIO aligns technology with business strategy at the executive level; the CTO leads technology direction; the CISO leads security.	Mixing up CIO and CTO, or choosing by tenure.	“Align technology investments with business strategy.”
7	Balanced scorecard perspectives	Financial, customer, internal process, and learning and growth perspectives balance IT measurement.	Filing a measure by what it costs rather than what it tracks.	A metric to place in a perspective.
8	Core vs. non-core sourcing	Keep capabilities that create competitive advantage in-house; commodity functions are candidates for outsourcing or shared services.	Outsourcing the differentiator or insourcing commodities.	A proprietary system listed next to commodity services.

Course scope (public description): Building a Successful IT Organization addresses what makes a successful IT division by considering the functions, roles, and responsibilities of IT professionals and specialists across various organizational environments and situations. Students will also learn to develop a strategic plan, including goal setting, implementation planning, and understanding IT organizational structure.